

OVERFISHING AND BYCATCH

Modern commercial fishing is so intense that many fish are becoming rare. Bigger ships, better nets, and new technology for locating fish are no longer resulting in larger catches, and the global fish catch actually fell by 13 percent between 1994 and 2003. The variety of fish found along coasts has also been badly affected. Other marine wildlife is threatened by the accidental bycatch of turtles, seabirds, dolphins, and seals, as well as the wrong kind of fish. Overfishing is threatening to drive some species, such as albatrosses, to global extinction.

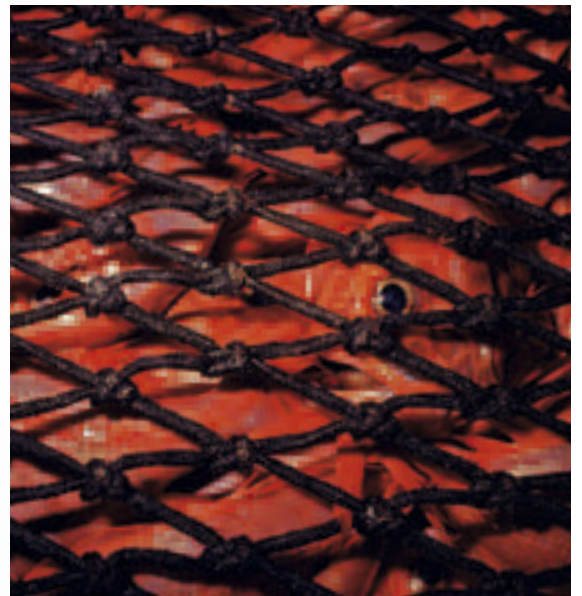
WORLD DEMAND



The massive increase in the world's human population is putting extreme pressure on some natural resources, including sea fish. The annual global fish catch now stands at more than 83 million tons (75 million metric tons). Some is sold whole in markets like this, but most is frozen or canned. Fish populations are collapsing, and if the current trend continues, most of the world's fish stocks will be wiped out by 2050.

◀ NETTING SHOALS

Modern fish-location techniques and purse seine nets make it possible to catch entire shoals of fish. This may seem rather like netting a football crowd, but it is more like destroying an isolated tribe with its own genetic identity. It reduces the genetic variety of the species, making it more vulnerable to extinction.



▲ NO TIME TO BREED

Some fish like these orange roughy do not breed until they are several years old, and even then they breed slowly. They cannot make up for losses caused by intensive fishing, so they go into steep decline. Before long they may be virtually extinct.

